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Revisiting the *Big Middle*: an fsQCA approach to unpack a large value market from a product specialist retailer's perspective

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Abstract

Purpose – Identifying the patterns of retail institutional change has piqued the interest of retail academics for nearly a century. The Big Middle hypothesis is one of the most recent and hybridized versions of similar theories. According to it, retailers seeking a dominant position in retailing can migrate into the Big Middle, the largest market segment, by specializing in a large market with a broad product assortment or by focusing on a specific product category and simultaneously catering for multiple segments at the same time. This study provides empirical evidence for the latter proposition by employing fuzzy-set qualitative comparative analysis (fsQCA) on the case of UNIQLO, a Japanese clothing specialist retailing giant.

Design/methodology/approach – The authors devised a survey to assess (1) consumers' perceptions of UNIQLO's store attributes and (2) their perceived distance between the UNIQLO and potential competitors. The authors used fsQCA procedures to identify multiple confluences of causal conditions that led to a high level of consumer patronage for UNIQLO from various market segments.

Findings – The findings show that UNIQLO's dominance in the Big Middle stems not only from capturing a sizable homogeneous market but from aggregating multiple heterogeneous market segments with disparities of various types. This finding explains how a specialty store retailer achieves its Big Middle position.

Research limitations/implications – The findings gleaned from fsQCA are not statistically generalisable. It, therefore, is essential to ensure whether similar phenomena are observed under different spatiotemporal settings. Concerning the scope of the research, this study's finding is pertinent to only one part of the Big Middle hypothesis. Future studies are required to cover other dimensions of the Big Middle, including the generalist retailer's cases of the Big Middle.

Practical implications – The results of this study may present a valuable tool to deepen retailers' understandings on; (1) the multiple causal recipes of customer patronages to their retail offerings, (2) who the pure fans of their stores are, (3) who their principal rivals are in the mind space of the consumers, and (4) their overall market position upon aiming to realise the Big Middle. It will give retail managers an insight into how to design, implement, and churn an efficient and effective RBM.

Originality/value – The study's originality is in empirically scrutinizing and elaborating a part of the mechanism of retail change heralded by the Big Middle hypothesis.

Keywords Retailing, Specialty store, *Big middle*, Fuzzy-set QCA, Set-theoretic method, UNIQLO, Retail change, RBM, Fast retailing

Paper type Research paper

1. Introduction

Since the early 1930s, when Paul Nystrom, a pioneer in retail studies, first depicted its cyclical pattern in US retailing, institutional change in retailing has attracted significant scholarly

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attention in retailing and related disciplines (Azuma, 2019; Nystrom, 1915; Savitt, 1989). As a result of a group of academics' long-term efforts, several so-called classic hypotheses of retail change emerged, including the Retail Accordion (Hower, 1943; Hollander, 1966), wheel of retailing (Hollander, 1960; McNair, 1958; McNair and May, 1976), Retail Vacua (Nielsen, 1966), Retail Lifecycle (Davidson *et al.*, 1976; Davidson and Johnson, 1981; Levitt, 1965), and dialectic model (Maronick and Walker, 1974). Each of these conceptual models succeeded, at least partially, in illustrating the patterns and mechanisms of institutional change in retailing in a specific temporal and geographical context.

None of these classic "textbook" hypotheses addresses universal theories beyond the different evolutionary patterns among various retail types and the spatiotemporal nature of retail development. Retailing is essentially a local business that is vulnerable to environmental factors that define a community in a given spatiotemporal setting. Some aspects of production, consumption, legislation, technology and social infrastructure create a unique context that determines retailing roles in a given spatiotemporal environment. Furthermore, factors such as economic efficiencies, power inequities in the distribution channel, innovative behaviors of actors therein, and interactions among the system's components promote retailing evolution (Gauri *et al.*, 2008; McArthur *et al.*, 2016).

Given the inherent complexity of retailing, the scope of a single parsimonious synthesis cannot capture the entirety of the retail structure in different economies and geographies. The emergence of a new retail format never completely replaces the traditional, less efficient ones, leaving the retailing system in a given economy to form an intricate mosaic pattern with old and new, dominant and peripheral, and big and small coexisting. As a result of the fundamental nature of retail change, a medium-range theory that depicts the pattern of retail change under well-specified conditions is required.

The *Big Middle* concept, coined by Levy *et al.* (2005), is one of the latest versions of retail change synthesis. Unlike many of the previously mentioned classic hypotheses, the *Big Middle* model has a clear line of demarcation in terms of its theoretical scope, which is confined to large-scale retailing. It posits that a retailer seeking to expand frequently attempts to migrate into the *Big Middle*, the largest retailing segment in a given market, by trading up or down from their original position in the retail landscape. Those who successfully secure and strengthen their positions in the *Big Middle* may prosper in the most profitable market. However, intense competition within the *Big Middle* frequently drives players out, allowing newcomers to enter the "extended" wheel of retailing. This synthesis's potential novelty incorporates both notions of trading up and trading down, as well as the rise and fall of players seeking growth and survival in the *Big Middle*. According to Levy *et al.* (2005), retailers can only enter the *Big Middle* through either of two ways: (1) market specialization by generalizing their product assortment or (2) product specialization catering to multiply market segments at the same time.

This paper empirically tests the latter proposition of the *Big Middle* hypothesis, using fuzzy-set qualitative comparative analysis (fsQCA) on the single case of UNIQLO, which has maintained its status in the *Big Middle* for the past 20 years. The findings of this study show how a product specialist retailer establishes a presence in the *Big Middle* by aggregating multiple heterogeneous market segments that the retailer attracts through a single retailing mix.

The purpose of this research is to make academic contributions to the advancement of the medium-term theory of institutional change in retailing. Although retail change theories and hypotheses have been widely debated (Savitt, 1989), few empirical studies have examined the validity and reliability of several classic retail change theories, with some exceptions, such as Kubo's study (2017). There has been little evidence to back the propositions in textual theorizations, owing primarily from scarcity of historical materials required to precisely trace the process of change, the barrage to empirical testing of these

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models. This research has enough material to use an empirical methodology because it has comprehensive knowledge of the case study firm from a previous series of process-tracing-based research.

Synthesizing general patterns of retail change is critical for predicting the future outlook of retailing's institutional structure amid constant change. Advances in retail and related technologies and infrastructure over the past three decades and retailers' (inter-) organizational responses have dramatically increased their resources and capabilities in flexibly designing and executing retailing formats to meet constantly changing consumer needs (Grewal *et al.*, 2018; Shanker *et al.*, 2020). The pace of retail change and its growing width and depth has become a dynamic phenomenon in a progressively shorter time.

For the following reasons, it is critical to investigate and empirically test the medium-range theory of retail change. For starters, retailing is an important part of the social system because it provides utility such as time, place, and product assortment. This function is synonymous with the ability to predict and merchandize products at the right time and place, in any combination and lot size, at reasonable costs, and without relying on original producers (McArthur *et al.*, 2016). Given the complexity in the production and consumption ends of the economic system (Dreesmann, 1968) within the global production network, the socioeconomic roles of retailing and distribution are becoming increasingly succinct (Pickles *et al.*, 2015; Tokatli, 2012). Second, developing a medium-term theory on the general patterns of retail change will aid in predicting the future outlook of transforming the dominant segment of retailing. Sophistication in theoretical scope is becoming essential as retail change expands in an increasingly shorter period.

The rest of this paper is organized as follows. We begin by discussing the fundamental logic behind the *Big Middle* synthesis in comparison to its classic predecessors. A discussion on the *Big Middle*'s basic premises emphasizes the empirical research to further its explanatory power. Based on the findings of previous studies, we develop a set of research hypotheses. Then, from this perspective of specialty store retailing, we empirically investigate the actual compositions of the *Big Middle* segment. We use fsQCA on survey data about UNIQLO customer satisfaction and perceptions of the various store attributes in comparison to potential competitors. The analyses' set-theoretic solutions raised theoretical and practical implications for the *Big Middle* hypothesis of retail change proposition.

2. The *Big Middle* hypothesis and the propositions of the research

2.1 The novelties of the Big Middle hypothesis of retail change

The *Big Middle* concept (Levy *et al.*, 2005) is a relatively new variant of retail change theories. The classic synthesis that sheds light on this topic tends to approach the issue from a cyclical, conflict, or environmental perspective (Brown, 1987). Power inequities, economic efficiencies, innovative behaviors, and interdependencies within the retail and distribution system, according to other principal schools, derive retail structure transformation. The *Big Middle* hypothesis, on the other hand, is remarkably hybridized in its fundamental nature. It combines retail lifecycle elements by emphasizing the effects of a retailer's birth and death, the incremental economies of scale in reaching the *Big Middle,* and the price and nonprice offerings factor (Reynolds *et al.*, 2007).

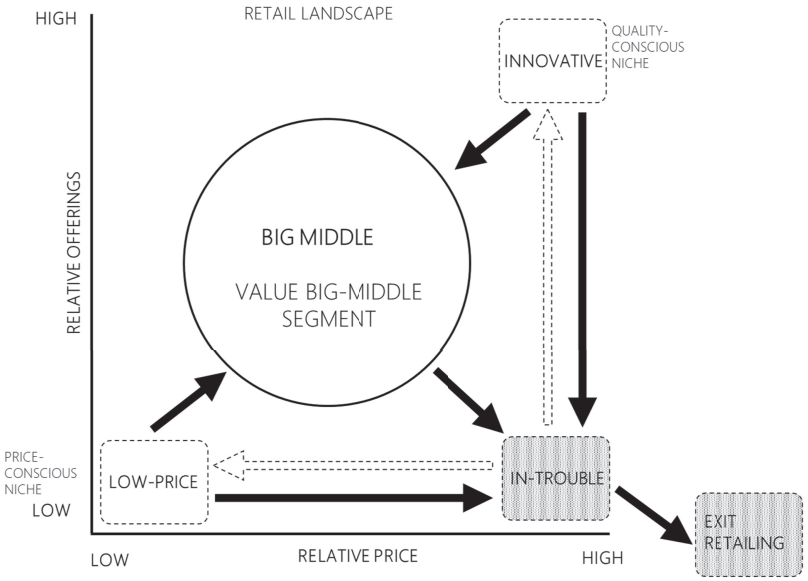
Although there are several classic "textbook" theories of retail change, none of them has a comprehensive explanatory power. The wheel of retailing, for example, stands on the oversimplified assumption that a retailer can only evolve by trading up its retail offerings. According to this hypothesis, an innovative retail concept emerges from the retail landscape's low-price and nominal-service outskirts. A successful innovator eventually faces challenges from the imitators and upgrades its retail offerings to differentiate itself. With successful

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upgrading, another group of followers forces the original innovator to trade up further, to the point of becoming an upmarket retailer with quality products and excellent service, the polar opposite of what the retailer initially was. As a result, the retailer loses its initial appeal to the initial customer base and is a forced exit, allowing another innovator to emerge retail landscape's discount fringe, thus revolving the wheel of retailing (Hollander, 1960; McNair, 1958; McNair and May, 1976). The flaw in this hypothesis is that the innovator only appears in the retail landscape's low service/low-price (low–low) (see Figure 1), which does not apply to various cases of retailing format innovation.

Nielsen's (1966) *Retail Vacua* synthesis also has flaws, but it appears to overcome the oversimplification of the retail change process embedded in the *wheel of retailing*. Nielsen posited that retailers located in the low–low or high–high niches of the consumers' preference curve make an upward or downward transition to the point on the curve where consumers' demands peak. Trading up/down toward this quasi *Big Middle* segment of the market creates a vacuum at either end of the retail landscape, and innovators emerge on the outskirts to fill these gaps. Although this hypothesis elucidates retailers' orientations toward the business scale as a succinct driver of retail change, it is too obscure and static regarding those who successfully migrate to the most significant part of the retail market.

The coarseness of the classic retail change synthesis highlights another dimension in which the *Big Middle* model is more prominent and hybridized than others. Its creation was based on a historical overview of the dominant segment of modern American retailing. This origin clarifies the existence of two absolute paths by which retailers transition to the *Big Middle*: market or a product specialization (Levy *et al.*, 2005). A typical market example of generalization is *Big Middle* retailers shifting toward mass-merchandizers with a broader product assortment to cater to customers' everyday lives. Specialist retailers advance to the *Big Middle* by operating in a variety of market segments with a standard retailing format and business model (RBM). Retailers that successfully migrate through one of these pathways typically leverage a combination of factors, including innovative merchandising, use of



Source(s): Adapted from Levy *et al.*, 2005

Figure 1.
Retail landscape and the Big Middle

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advanced technologies (Pantano, 2014; Pantano and Timmermans, 2014; Pantano *et al.*, 2018; Reinartz *et al.*, 2019; Shankar and Yadav, 2011; Shanker *et al.*, 2020), price optimization (Gauri *et al.*, 2008), well-coordinated retail supply chain management (Brown *et al.*, 2005; Sorescu *et al.*, 2011), and the power of the store name/image (Botschen and Wegerer, 2017; Levy *et al.*, 2005).

Under the given condition, the *Big Middle* accounts for the most significant retail market segment, as illustrated in Figure 1. It is defined as the market space in which retail giants compete for dominance over consumer expenditures. This value of a segment of the retail market has the greatest number of potential customers (Brown *et al.*, 2005; Levy *et al.*, 2005). Given the diversity of consumer demands and the increasingly fragmented nature of the current retail market, latent opportunities for niche and small retailers appear to be solid. Staying within a niche market, on the other hand, is insufficient for retailers seeking a stable orientation toward the desired long-term growth and profitability.

Retailers must transition to volume-driven retailers and abandon (1) the innovative and premium fringe aimed at the quality-conscious niche or (2) the low-price fringe aimed at the price-conscious niche. To move into the *Big Middle*, upmarket retailers of the former type offer a larger population of consumers the same consistency in quality innovation, but at a lower price. Retailers of the latter type explore ways to upgraded retail offerings to consumers without sacrificing their original price-based strength (Levy *et al.*, 2005). The motivations of retailers to tap into the *Big Middle* and establish such strong footholds for sustainable growth translate into the driving force behind retailing's institutional change.

Concerning the large-scale dominant segment of retailing, the *Big Middle* hypothesis provides a clear-cut and practical perspective on the mechanism of institutional change. Nevertheless, since its inception in the early 2000s, it has provided little empirical evidence. Insufficient information exists to answer questions, like "How can a retailer successfully migrate to the *Big Middle*, appeal to a large population of consumers, and win their patronage? What exactly does the 'mass' in the *Big Middle* represent? Is there a single sizable homogeneous segment? Is a Big *Middle* retailer otherwise catering to a conglomeration of smaller market segments with a single versatile retail offering?" Most advanced economies are in the stage of consumer society maturity, where dramatic growth rarely occurs in the retail market. Therefore, a retailer seeking opportunities in the *Big Middle* must consistently fine-tune its retailing format and RBM to create and deliver superior value offerings to more consumers than competitors.

2.2 Current state of the research on the Big Middle

Although several well-known case studies exist on *Big Middle* retailers, they are mostly descriptive, providing brief historical accounts of cases and revealing the general characteristics of their RBMs. Although these studies make significant contributions to knowledge sharing and accumulating in the topic area, a general lack of explicitly structured research methodologies prevents them from advancing the *Big Middle* hypothesis. Formalizing the procedures and approaches in various case study techniques is one of the methodological challenges in social science. It is also critical to gain a better understanding of their ontological and epistemological foundations.

Case-based development, refinement, and testing of syntheses as well as their methodological rigors (Beach and Pedersen, 2019), from an exciting area of investigation, methodological rigors, form an exciting area of exploration, and methodologies from multiple disciplines have been investigated. A series of studies (Azuma, 2017; Azuma *et al.*, 2021) attempted to unpack the causal mechanism (or processes) (Beach and Pedersen, 2019; Gerring, 2006; Mahoney and Terrie, 2009) by which a retailer enters a long-term sustainable growth path in the *Big Middle*. The process-tracing method is a within-case causal inference

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technique that is based on a thorough examination of a unique and complex single historical case (Falleti, 2006; Falleti and Lynch, 2008) and one of the most useful methodological toolkits for determining the causal mechanism.

The results from a longitudinal process tracing of UNIQLO reveal that the company's transition from a humble independent retailer in a geographical periphery represents an iterative process, where the company maneuvered to overcome the institutional constraints within the Japanese textiles and clothing industry. UNIQLO needed to overcome the traditional distribution channel structure, where clothing suppliers possessed the power. Seizing price-setting autonomy was critical to this end, necessitating the development of UNIQLO's own-brand merchandising initiative. This necessitated a sufficient retail store network to ensure the significant purchasing power required to negotiate with world-class suppliers. This series of iterative actions eventually provided UNIQLO with the necessary networked resources and capabilities to launch an own-brand merchandising program from the source to better satisfy *Big Middle* consumers for functional and versatile casual clothing (Azuma, 2017; Azuma *et al.*, 2021).

Since the late 2000s, UNIQLO's shift toward more sustainable growth has portrayed a slightly different picture. UNIQLO carefully augmented its interorganizational network in the retail supply chain during the incremental processes. The company developed direct relationships with a small number of world-class parties throughout the retail supply chain, from the material/product development stage to the distribution processing and risk bearings of finished goods inventories. A network of organizations implemented a supply chain-wide synchronization of critical information, allowing them to respond to the demand change in a flexible manner. Knowledge and technology transfer to its suppliers through an in-house team of experts also improved production, management, and quality assurance. This series of RBM enhancement resulted in a well-defined retailing mix, that is, experiential space for its customers (Grewal *et al.*, 2009; Levy and Weitz, 2012) centered on a robust collection of own-brand merchandize. UNIQLO was successful in designing and coordinating its retailing mix to fully utilize both organizational and interorganizational resources within the RBM (Azuma *et al.*, 2021).

Despite previous research identifying the historical process by which retailers arrived at the *Big Middle*, there is little empirical evidence for the mechanisms behind the transition. This unexplored area of further research is closely related to the peculiarity and limitation of the process-tracing technique, which is effective when chronologically unpacking the causal mechanism and process leading to a particular outcome of a specific complex and unique social phenomenon. This technique, on the other hand, does not cover the research context in which a cross-sectional image of a specific object requires close empirical scrutiny. In other words, an alternative approach is mandatory to investigate the internal composition of the *Big Middle* realized by a product specialist. For this purpose, we adopted fsQCA, which allows empirically investigating the conjunctures of causal conditions leading to a specific outcome.

2.3 Research propositions

The Retail Accordion hypothesis proposed by Staley Hollander (1966) provides the theoretical underpinning for propositions in this study. He described retailing's institutional changes as an oscillation between its generalist and specialist poles. Hollander's basic understanding of such cyclical change raises another question about how retailers compete when the trade center shifts incrementally from one end of the spectrum to the other, from generalist to the specialist, and vice versa.

The following assumptions underpin the central idea of this research. A product specialist retailer.

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(1) Develops an RBM that attracts customers' attention with a clearly defined focused product assortment;

(2) Adjusts the depth and width of the product assortment to incrementally capture the demands in the adjacent markets (or product categories);

(3) Reaches the *Big Middle* by absorbing substantial parts of competitors' customer base and turning them into patrons;

(4) Strengthens its presence in the *Big Middle* by continuously fine-tuning its RBM.

These assumptions are synonymous with the unstated process in the Retail Accordion, where specialist (generalist) retailers transform into a (quasi)-generalist (specialist) to respond to the constantly changing retail environment. A product specialist retailer who reaches the *Big Middle* is likely to stand on the shoulders of several innately heterogeneous market segments. A specialist retailer often needs to adjust its retail offerings to appeal to more diverse consumers in heterogeneous market segments when entering the *Big Middle* and attempting to secure its position. This understanding of the *Big Middle* and the Retail Accordion resulted in the research propositions listed below.

Proposition 1. There are multiple pathways through which consumers patronize the same single retailer in the Big Middle. In other words, a Big Middle specialist retailer can attract varied types of consumers with a unified retailing mix offering.

Proposition 2. A specialty store retailer's dominant position in the Big Middle comprises a conjuncture(s)/aggregation(s) of various smaller market segments, constituting a sizable super segment. The actual Big Middle achieved by a specialist retailer has a more complex structure than what is animated by Levy *et al.* (2005).

Proposition 3. A product specialist retailer's large value segment in the Big Middle comprises multiple market segments that partially overlap with its competitors'. A specialist retailer in the mature economy reaches the position in the Big Middle by winning the customer bases that coincide with its competitors.

3. Research methodology

3.1 Analytical approach

To empirically test these hypotheses, we used fsQCA to determine whether the *Big Middle* a retailer realizes is a single mass market, an aggregation of various smaller market segments, or their combinations of the two. We chose fsQCA because we needed to deal with customer cognition. Customer perceptions include things how much they agree with a particular question. Therefore, it is better suited for coding on fuzzy sets that allow partial membership to a given condition than crisp sets with a binary code of 0/1.

For two primary reasons, this method is more relevant than mainstream conventional statistical methods such as multivariate regression analysis (MRA). First, fsQCA assumes that multiple causal paths can lead to the same single outcome. Thus, a retailer reaching the *Big Middle* attracts consumers who prioritize heterogeneous conjunctures of the retailing mix. Second, retailing "mix" is essentially a strategic concept incorporating the combined effects of its components rather than the sum of impacts of individual variables of MRA, which is based on the additive principle of mutually exclusive causal (independent) variables (Azuma *et al.*, 2020a, b, c; Ragin, 1987/2014), does not account for these effects. Finally, fsQCA

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allows for various combinations of causal conditions for a given outcome and its negation. Therefore, a set-theoretic perspective is advantageous for addressing the study's propositions.

3.2 Outline of the survey

We used UNIQLO as a single example. UNIQLO, the main arm of Fast Retailing, has a global network of 2,300 stores in over 25 countries and regions. It is one of the world's largest clothing specialist retail multiples. UNIQLO controls above 10% of the clothing retail market in Japan.

We created a questionnaire to assess consumers' perceptions of UNIQLO's various retailing mix attributes and their perceived distance between UNIQLO and ten other clothing retailers with potential discrepancies in the *Big Middle* customer base. These ten retailers represent popular names in Japanese clothing retailing, including domestic and international key players from five primary categories that include UNIQLO's product assortment (Table 1).

Through the Japanese research firm GMO Research Inc., we conducted an online survey of urban consumers in Greater Tokyo (Tokyo, Kanagawa, Chiba, and Saitama) and Kansai regions (Osaka, Kyoto, and Hyogo). The survey was limited to these seven prefectures in Japan because UNIQLO and all other retailers included in the study operated their stores, providing consumers with a wide range of clothing store options.

The timing of data collection (2015) is appropriate to confirm the proposition since UNIQLO was experiencing a rapid yet steady growth toward the *Big Middle* both domestically and internationally, marking a critical juncture in its historical development. It is also noteworthy that UNIQLO's acceleration around the time of the survey was primarily driven by its physical store-based activities. Since then, UNIQLO's strategic focus has shifted to e-commerce and omnichannel development (Azuma *et al.*, 2021). Therefore, it is reasonable to conclude that the data set collected through our 2015 survey addresses the need to measure consumers' perceptions of UNIQLO in comparison to its potential competitors on a physical store basis.

The survey was conducted between April 6 and 7, 2015 and was closed when respondents exceeded 1,100. Of a total of 1,198 responses, those who were unaware of UNIQLO ($n = 38$) and who submitted incomplete responses were eliminated, resulting in 888 valid responses. The respondents' average age was 41.43 years, with a range of 22–74 years (standard deviation = 11.425 years). The respondents were divided into 43.8 percent females and 56.2% males; 66.8% lived in Greater Tokyo, while the rest lived in the Kansai Region.

3.3 Measurements

3.3.1 The outcome set for the analysis with fsQCA procedures. The outcome set for the analysis with fs QCA procedures contained three items, including overall satisfaction, usage status, and intention to shop, which reflected the generally accepted outcome set for this type of study. This decision is supported by a recent meta-analysis by Blut *et al.* (2018). All responses were gathered using a five-point Likert scale, and factor scores for these items were used in the analyses.

3.3.2 Causal conditions set for the analysis with fsQCA procedures. Using fsQCA procedures, we obtained a set of causal conditions for the analysis that corresponded to the six domains of retailing mix defined by Levy and Weitz (2012), with some elaborations to cover the critical aspects of UNIQLO's retailing mix. In addition, we incorporated knowledge gained from a series of longitudinal process-tracing studies on UNIQLO into the survey design, and 70 items were designated as conditional (independent) variables.

An exploratory factor analysis (maximum likelihood model with Promax rotation) conducted in a stepwise manner converged the variables down to four principal factors (see

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Table 1.
Brief profiles of the retailers analyzed concerning UNIQLO in this study

Category	Retail store name	Parent company	FY 2015 sales (bil. Yen)	No. of store in Japan	Characteristics	Typical store locations
–	UNIQLO	Fast Retailing Co Ltd	753.6	846	Life wear' concept consists of own- brand product assortment that places utmost focuses on basic and functional features of clothing with high quality and affordable price	CBD, urban shopping centres, suburban shopping centres
Discount Mens/Womens Business Suits Specialist Retail Multiples	AOYAMA	Aoyama Trading Co Ltd	164.2	796	Low-price business suits for both men and women	Primarily suburban "road-side" location
	AOKI	Aoki Holdings Inc	169.2	565		
Upmarket "Smart" Casual Clothing Speciality Stores	United Arrows	UNITED ARROWS LTD	29.8	24	Product assortment with mens and womens designers' clothing and private-brand	CBD and urban shopping centres
	Beams	Beams Co. Ltd	7.95	161		
Global Fashion-Forward Casual Clothing Speciality Store Retail Multiples	H&M	H&M Hennes andMauritz AB	49.6	53	Globally renowned "fast fashion" retailer	CBD and suburban shopping centres
	Zara	Inditex, Industria de Diseño Textil SA	50.1	99	The largest "fast fashion" clothing specialist multiple in the world	
Domestic Low-price Casual Clothing Speciality Store Retail Multiples	Right-on	Right-On Inc	76.6	499	National-brand denim items and own-brand casual clothing for young men and women	Suburban "road-side" location, suburban shopping centres and urban shopping cenres
	Honeys	Honeys Co Ltd	46.7	847	Low-price trend-oriented own-brand product assortment for young women	Suburban shopping centres and urban shopping centres
	Shimamura	Shimamura Co Ltd	436.6	1,339	Low-price product assortment covering the needs from casual clothing to formal wears for men, women and kids	Primarily suburban residential areas
Low-price Fashion-forward Casual Clothing Retail Multiple arm of Fast Retailing	GU	Fast Retailing Co Ltd	137.6	307	Emphasises low price and trend fashion orientation in product assortment that covers men, women, kids, and athletic clothing	Suburban location and CBD

Source(s): Compiled by the authors based on each company's information

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Table 2). Factors in the following categories were excluded: (1) items with low commonality, (2) items with high factor loading scores on multiple factors, and (3) items with factor loading scores less than 0.6.

We used a five-point Likert scale to assess the perceived similarity between UNIQLO and the other stores listed in Table 1, with higher scores representing more significant similarity. We incorporated G.U. among the ten store names because Fast Retailing operates this more trend-forward and lower price specialist retail multiple to complement UNIQLO in the *Big Middle* [1].

3.3.3 Common method problem. Because we collected the data on the outcome and conditional variables from a single source, we conducted Herman's single factor test to check the presence of the common method problems (Podsakoff *et al.*, 2003). A factor analysis (principal factor method with no rotation) of all observed variables resulted in the identification of four factors. The former test's factor loading accounted for 23.59% of the total, indicating a negligible level of common method bias.

4. Analyses and findings

4.1 Reliability and validity of the constructs

The outcome and conditional variables on the retailing mix dimensions of UNIQLO are constructs comprising several observed variables. As a result, before running fsQCA, we double-checked their dependability and validity and found no issues. Cronbach's alpha and composite reliability were used to assess reliability. All constructs outperformed the commonly accepted standard values of 0.70 and 0.60 (Bagozzi and Yi, 1988; Nunnally, 1978). A confirmatory factor analysis (most likelihood method) conducted on the five constructs showed a good fit, with $\chi^2 = 378.718$, df. = 109, CFI = 0.969, SRMR = 0.039, and RMSEA = 0.053 (Hair *et al.*, 2013), confirming their unidimensionality. The path coefficients of latent variables to observed variables were greater than 0.5 and statistically significant at 0.1% (Bagozzi and Yi, 1988). As shown in Table 3, the average variance extracted (AVE) scores were significantly higher than the widely used cutoff level of 0.5, exceeding the square of the correlation coefficient between the constructs (Fornell and Larcker, 1981).

4.2 Data calibration

After creating composite conditions with confirmatory factor analysis to confirm the necessary conditions, we used fsQCA procedures to calibrate the outcome and the conditions set for the analysis (Berg-Schlosser and De Meur, 2016; Kahwati and Kane, 2020; Ragin, 2000, 2008; Rihoux and Ragin, 2009). This calibration assigned a membership score ranging from 1 (complete nonmembership) to 5 (complete membership) to individual conditions and outcomes. There are two calibration methods: direct and indirect. We used the former because this is a large-N variant of fsQCA and the data generally follow a normal distribution. The quartile of the factor scores was used to calibrate all data.

Regarding the conditions on consumers' perceived distance between UNIQLO and other principle retail stores, Likert scale responses between 1 and 5 demarcated the full nonmembership (1), cross-over point (3), and full membership (5). These dataset treatments made it simple to obtain an incomplete truth table. We used a truth table algorithm to examine conjunctural conditions, relying on the consistency score for each combination. This procedure eliminated conjunctures with insignificant validity [consistency 0.75, according to Ragin (2008)], resulting in a complete truth table for use in the QCA package in R. Except for the gender, location, and age dummies, all conditions and outcomes were in the fuzzy-set membership scores.

4.3 Analytical model

The outcome of our analytical model was the level of customer patronage to UNIQLO. The conditions incorporated into the model were (1) merchandising excellence, (2) attractiveness

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Variables	Items	Mean	Standard deviation	Standardised coefficient	Reliability
Outcome variable. Store Patronage	I want to shop at the store	3.20	0.966	0.904	CA = 0.871
	I am a regular shopper at the store	3.09	1.098	0.847	CR = 0.878
	My overall satisfaction level with the store is high	3.36	0.916	0.767	
Conditional variable 1. Merchandising Excellence	The product assortment has a rich selection of famous brands' items	2.14	1.035	0.75	CA = 0.856 CR = 0.856
	The store has a unique and differentiated selection of a variety of brands	2.47	1.097	0.741	
	The product assortment of the store has a sense of status	2.51	0.998	0.803	
	The store has a somewhat luxurious atmosphere	2.28	0.962	0.714	
	The price setting is not low, but I can trust the items I purchase from this store	2.52	0.954	0.677	
Conditional variable 2. Attractiveness of Price Promotion	The store holds a special sale regularly	3.16	0.988	0.853	CA = 0.878 CR = 0.878
	The store offers us big discounts when holding a special sale	2.97	0.926	0.831	
	The store holds special events and limited-time sales frequently	3.03	1.009	0.73	
	The store always puts the item I would like to purchase on sale	3.06	0.952	0.802	
Conditional variable 3. Store Personnel's fit with Store Environment	The character of the sales personnel fits well with the store atmosphere	3.03	0.879	0.884	CA = 0.897 CR = 0.899
	The character of the sales personnel fits well with the image of the store's customers	3.04	0.870	0.91	
	The sales personnel's appearances and styles are suitable for the store's product and product assortment grade	3.14	0.860	0.798	
Conditional variable 4. Convenient Store Location	The store has a good location close to the railway station	3.57	1.068	0.906	CA = 0.871 CR = 0.872
	The store locates in the city centre and easily accessible by public transports	3.59	1.063	0.852	

Table 2.
The results of the confirmatory factor analysis

Source(s): Authors

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of price promotion, (3) store personnel's fit with the store environment, (4) convenience of store location, (5) respondents' gender (crisp set of 1:female, 0:male), (6) respondents' place of residence (crisp set of 1: Greater Tokyo, 0: Kansai region), (7) respondents' age (crisp set of 1: Older (42 years old and above), 0: Younger (41 years old and below) and (8–10) the perceived similarity between UNIQLO and the retailers listed in Table 1.

The listed retailers were divided into five categories, reflecting the characteristics of their retailing mix. Discount business suit retailers are represented by Category A. UNIQLO's potential competitors in the upper-market "smart casual" clothing retailing are represented by Category B. Category C represents the international behemoths H&M and Zara, while Category D represents the low-cost domestic clothing specialist multiples. Finally, Category E differs slightly in that it refers to G.U., a price-conscious and trend-forward division of Fast Retailing, UNIQLO's parent company. The standard fsQCA procedure was performed to identify the causal conjunctures leading to consumers' high patronage of UNIQLO.

4.4 Findings from the analysis

We analyzed with fsQCA procedures using the QCA package in R. Although this study is based on a large-N and thus should be relatively free of problems caused by logical remainders (nonobserved combinations of causal conditions), we took the step of removing the logical remainders from our dataset. It is because our analytical model incorporated as many as ten causal conditions, meaning a significant likelihood of generating an excess of logical remainders (Fiss, 2011; Pattyn, 2012).

The principal results gleaned from the fsQCA procedures are presented in Table 4.

While we obtained thirty-nine causal conjunctures in total, when all retailer categories were considered, the majority of those recipes were found to have negligible effects, based on their unique coverage scores. As a result, we present in Table 4 the nineteen solution terms with unique coverage scores of 0.01 or higher. All thirty-nine solution terms are in Appendix 2.

As the results in Table 4 show, the conditions "personnel's fit with the store environment of the UNIQLO store" and "convenience of the store location" were present in all solution terms satisfying the requirement for Table 4, even when the solution terms were outside the boundaries of retailer categories (see Table 1). The former is present in all thirty-nine causal conjunctures, which is a necessary condition for the outcome. This single necessary condition implies that UNIQLO's strong focus on coordinating and managing its retailing format's front-end activities and personnel creates a universally appealing environment for the consumers in varied market segments. In addition to these two conditions, "attractiveness of price promotion" is present in all solution terms except E−5, which has to do with G.U., a lower-cost and more trend-oriented UNIQLO alternative under the Fast Retailing umbrella. It is a likelihood that the foundation for consumers' patronage to UNIQLO builds on its customer appeals with an easy-to-walk-in store atmosphere, store proximity, and the attraction of price promotion.

Table 3. Correlation coefficient and AVE

		1	2	3	4	AVE
1	Store patronage					0.707
2	Merchandising Excellence	0.414				0.545
3	Attractiveness of Price Promotion	0.502	0.515			0.644
4	Store Personnels' fit with Store Enviro	0.088	0.380	0.286		0.749
5	Convenient Store Location	0.543	0.537	0.561	0.386	0.773

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UNIQLO v.s.								similarity to						
Discount Mens / Womens Business Suits Specialist Retail Multiples (AOYAMA and AOKI)														
Solution Term	MD	PPR	PER	ACC	GEN	AREA	AGE	AOYAMA	AOKI	Raw Coverage	Unique Coverage	PRI Consittency	Solution Coverage	Solution Consistency
A-1	●	●	●	●	☒	☒	●	☒		0.023	0.015	0.838		
A-2	●	●	●	●	●	☒	●	●		0.047	0.047	0.782		
A-3	●	●	●	●		●	●	●	●	0.169	0.051	0.771	0.289	0.850
A-5	☒	●	●	●	☒	☒		●	●	0.029	0.021	0.821		
A-7	●	●	●	●		●	●	☒	☒	0.105	0.020	0.792		
UNIQLO v.s.								similarity to						
Upmarket 'Smart' Casual Clothing Speciality Stores (United Arrows and Beams)														
Solution Term	MD	PPR	PER	ACC	GEN	AREA	AGE	United Arrows	BEAMS	Raw Coverage	Unique Coverage	PRI Consittency	Solution Coverage	Solution Consistency
B-1	●	●	●	●	☒	●	●			0.124	0.019	0.801		
B-3	●	●	●	●		●	●	●		0.173	0.030	0.774	0.320	0.855
B-4	●	●	●	●			●	☒	☒	0.163	0.011	0.815		
B-9		●	●	●	☒	☒	●	●	●	0.056	0.024	0.804		
UNIQLO v.s.								similarity to						
Global Fashion-Forward Casual Clothing Speciality Store Retail Multiples (H&M and Zara)														
Solution Term	MD	PPR	PER	ACC	GEN	AREA	AGE	H&M	ZARA	Raw Coverage	Unique Coverage	PRI Consittency	Solution Coverage	Solution Consistency
C-3	●	●	●	●	☒	●	●	●		0.068	0.016	0.786		
C-4	●	●	●	●	☒		●	☒	☒	0.121	0.048	0.778	0.209	0.852
C-6	●	●	●	●		☒	●	●	●	0.067	0.019	0.782		
UNIQLO v.s.								similarity to						
Domestic Low-price Casual Clothing Speciality Store Retail Multiples (Right-on, Honey's, and Shimamura)														
Solution Term	MD	PPR	PER	ACC	GEN	AREA	AGE	Right-on	Honeys	Shima-mura	Raw Coverage	Unique Coverage	PRI Consittency	Solution Coverage	Solution Consistency
D-1	●	●	●	●	☒	●	●				0.124	0.040	0.801		
D-6	☒	●	●	●		☒	☒	☒		☒	0.144	0.022	0.780	0.291	0.853
D-11		●	●	●	☒	☒	☒	●	●	●	0.037	0.016	0.815		
UNIQLO v.s.								similarity to						
GU (under Fast Retailing) : Low-price Fashion-forward Casual Clothing Retail Multiple														
Solution Term	MD	PPR	PER	ACC	GEN	AREA	AGE	GU			Raw Coverage	Unique Coverage	PRI Consittency	Solution Coverage	Solution Consistency
E-1	●	●	●	●		☒	●				0.114	0.017	0.795		
E-2	●	●	●	●			●	☒			0.291	0.146	0.785	0.341	0.845
E-3	☒	●	●	●	☒	☒		☒			0.030	0.018	0.827		
E-5	●		●	●	☒	●	●	●			0.060	0.013	0.812		

Note(s): ● (Full circle) indicates the presence of a condition

☒ (Crossed-out box) indicates the absence of a condition

MD = Merchandising Excellence, PPR = Attractiveness of Price Promotion,

PER = Store Personnel's Fit with the Store Environment, ACC = Convenient Store Location

GEN = Gender Dummy : 1 = Female, 0 = Male, AREA = Area Dummy: 1 = Reside in Greater Tokyo, 0 = Reside in Kansai

AGE = Age Dummy : 1 = Older (42 years old and above, 0 = Younger (41 years old and below)

Source(s): Authors

Table 4.
The principal results of the analyses

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A closer look at the individual solution terms in each retailer category group in Table 4 reveals the potential sufficiency of our analytical framework. The model was well established for each group and had explanatory power (see Appendix 2. for details). The solution consistency, an indicator to assess the model's validity, is distributed between 84.5–85.5%. The solution coverage, an indicator that evaluates the model's explanatory power, is distributed between 20.9–34.1%. Following the solution terms presented in Table 4 for each retailer category group, we can easily identify multiple causal conjunctures that lead to consumers patronizing UNIQLO.

Among the five solution terms in group-A, Solution term A-1 represents middle-aged males in Kansai who support all four retailing mix attributes of UNIQLO and shop there for casual clothing. A-7 is a group of middle-aged Kanto residents who buy casual clothing from UNIQLO and fully support the company's overall retail offerings. On the other hand, solution terms A-2 to A-5 imply that consumers in these conjunctures buy business outfits at UNIQLO. A-2 consumers are middle-aged female consumers in Kansai who have overall satisfaction with UNIQLO. A-3 are middle-aged Kanto consumers who evaluate retailing mix in the same way. A-5 consumers differ from those in A-2 and A-3 in that Kansai male consumers in this group consider UNIQLO's business outfits to be of lower merchandising quality but continue to shop there.

From the solution terms in Group-B, we can observe multiple pathways leading to consumers' patronage of UNIQLO against its potential rivalries in the smart casual clothing specialists in the upper market. B-1 represents Kanto's conservative gray-haired males who do not give a hoot about fashion. B-3 represents Kanto's middle-aged pragmatic consumers who see UNIQLO as a viable alternative to more upper-market clothing specialists. Male consumers of the same generation in Kansai (B-9) differ slightly from their counterparts in Kanto. Although they perceive UNIQLO being a smart casual clothing retailer, their assessment is based on nonmerchandising attributes of UNIQLO's retailing mix. B-4 consumers are identified as those middle-aged consumers who are aware of the upper-market smart casual specialist stores yet are somewhat fully content with UNIQLO.

Vis-à-vis the international casual clothing specialist retail multiples (H&M and ZARA), broadly speaking, there are two general tendencies. Consumers in C-3 and C-6 consider UNIQLO, along with H&M and ZARA, to be a fast-fashion retail multiple. Others (C-4) see UNIQLO as a specialist in basic casual clothing. C-3 represents middle-aged Kanto male consumers who value UNIQLO as a fashion-forward store because of its excellent merchandising, reasonable pricing, easy-to-walk-in environment, and store proximity. Similarly, middle-aged consumers in Kansai (C-6) prefer UNIQLO as a fast-fashion retailer with a positive overall retailing mix. C-4, on the other hand, represents middle-aged male consumers who enjoy purchasing basic casual clothing at UNIQLO.

Solution terms in Group-D identify three principal paths leading to consumers' patronage of UNIQLO. D-1 is synonymous with the solution term B-1, representing the fashion-conscious conservative middle-aged male in Kanto who likes UNIQLO and is satisfied with the overall retailing mix. In the D-6 solution term, middle-aged consumers in Kanto perceive UNIQLO as distinct from the major domestic powers in low-price casual clothing retailing and have favorable attitudes toward all four dimensions of UNIQLO's retailing mix. On the other hand, fashion unconscious middle-aged Kansai male consumers in D-11 shop at UNIQLO as one of the low-price casual clothing specialty stores.

Lastly, Group-E derived four primary solution terms. Consumers in E-2 and E-3 recognize UNIQLO differentiated from G.U, a lower price and fashion-forward alternative to UNIQLO under the umbrella of Fast Retailing. Gray hair consumers in E-2 appreciate UNIQLO's overall retailing mix, which revolves around its timeless basicness. Kansai male consumers in E-6 recognize the lack of trendiness and fashionableness in UNIQLO's merchandising.

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They still prefer its easy-to-walk-in environment, reasonable pricing, and easy access to the store. E-1 represents Kansai's middle-aged consumers who like UNIQLO and are satisfied with the overall retailing mix. Middle-aged Kanto male consumers in E-5 will be defined as those who value UNIQLO's down-to-earth atmosphere, convenient location, and trend-inspired basic casual merchandising more than price.

4.5 Verification of research propositions

Through scrutinizing the primary causal conjunctures presented in Table 4, a sufficient amount of empirical evidence to explain the mechanism behind the latent structure of the *Big Middle* that UNIQLO has achieved was confirmed. In relevance to the three propositions of this study, we can safely state the following.

Proposition 1. There are multiple pathways through which consumers patronize the same single retailer in the Big Middle. In other words, a Big Middle specialist retailer can attract varied types of consumers with a unified retailing mix offering.

Proposition 1 was well-supported, as there are as many as thirty-nine paths leading to consumers' patronage of UNIQLO when incorporating the nominal solution terms, and nineteen when only the primary ones are selected.

Proposition 2. A specialty store retailer's dominant position in the Big Middle comprises a conjuncture(s)/aggregation(s) of various smaller market segments, constituting a sizable super segment. The actual Big Middle achieved by a specialist retailer has a more complex structure than what is animated by Levy *et al.* (2005).

From the findings presented in the previous section, there are multiple causal recipes for consumers to patronage UNIQLO, and the patterns of conjuncture of causal conditions are diverse. Some of them have larger coverage scores than others. These results are sufficient to verify Proposition 2.

Proposition 3. A product specialist retailer's large value segment in the Big Middle comprises multiple market segments that partially overlap with its competitors'. A specialist retailer in the mature economy reaches the position in the Big Middle by winning the customer bases that coincide with its competitors.

Not only have we observed multiple pathways to consumers' patronage of UNIQLO and diverse patterns of the combination of causal conditions leading to the same outcome, but we have also confirmed that consumers identified UNIQLO in each of the solution term positions in relation to its (potential) competitors. Some of these solution terms identified the presence of cases in which UNIQLO customers coincided with customers of rival retailers at the same time.

5. Conclusion

A series of explorations on the solution terms of causal conjunctures to explain multiple paths leading to consumers' patronage of UNIQLO highlights the conclusion that a product specialist (Levy *et al.*, 2005) reaches the *Big Middle* not merely because of a large population with homogeneous demands. Attracting consumers from several smaller market segments results in the creation of another *Big Middle* dimension on an aggregate level, resulting in a

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large value segment. These smaller segments are frequently retained by competitors, or so-called blue oceans, with ideal positioning. By differentiating their retail offering, a *Big Middle* product specialist invariably encroaches on competitors' customer base in the formers. The latter status does not guarantee absolute continuity of the current position in the Big Middle. Further efforts in fine-tuning the retailing format and the RBM are essential.

5.1 Theoretical/practical implications

This study's theoretical implication is a potential contribution to elaborating the *Big Middle* hypothesis. We investigated the enormous value segment's internal structure that a product specialist retailer cultivates in the Big Middle, using set-theoretic causation from UNIQLO's experiences, in the latter half of the *Big Middle's* theoretical frontier. This study's potential academic contributions are to empirically confirm the following: (1) a product specialist retailer structures its *Big Middle* by aggregating various heterogeneous market segments rather than relying on a single mass market, (2) consumers representing each of these individual market segments have heterogeneous confluences of causal conditions to patronize a *Big Middle* product specialist retailer, and (3) such market segments include so-called blue oceans and retailers with significant overlaps with competitors. As a result, this study's findings are likely to shed light on the *Big Middle* hypothesis's theoretical soundness. A formalized research methodology will provide an analytical and theoretical foundation for future research to test this retail change model in various spatiotemporal and socio-cultural settings.

For retail practitioners, the results of this study may present a valuable tool to deepen understanding on the following: (1) the multiple causal recipes of customer patronages to their retail offerings, (2) identifying the pure fans of their stores, (3) ascertaining their principal rivals in the mind space of the consumers, and (4) their overall market position upon reaching the *Big Middle*. It will teach retail managers how to create, implement, and churn an efficient and effective RBM. The most likely means of achieving a consistent stream of growth in the domestic market, particularly in the mature economy, is to win customer bases that coincide with its latent and open competitors. Retailers attempting to defend themselves against the competitive pressures created by the *Big Middle* players may also use a series of analyses with the QCA procedure to plan their survival and identify future growth opportunities. As a result, QCA will assist practitioners in resolving both strategic and operational issues.

5.2 Limitations and future research

The study has certain limitations in its analytical scope and the method of verifying the research findings. The findings gleaned from fsQCA are not statistically generalizable. As a result, it is critical to determine whether similar phenomena occur in different spatiotemporal settings. It is also worth noting that, in recent years, the retail landscape has changed, at least partially, as a result of the advancement of online shopping and retailers' omnichannel strategies. This aspect of retail change may affect the overall concept of the *Big Middle*.

Concerning the scope of the research, this study empirically scrutinized only a single aspect of the *Big Middle*. According to the findings of fsQCA, the *Big Middle* realized by a product specialist retailer is a composite market made up of heterogeneous adjacent markets. This finding is only relevant to one aspect of the Big Middle hypothesis. Future research must address additional dimensions, such as (1) the Big Middle in generalist retailing, (2) (inter-) organizational relationship aspects of RBM, and (3) firm-market interactions. If these elements are successfully integrated, the Big Middle hypothesis will become more sophisticated and meaningful, both theoretically and practically.

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Note

1. For descriptive statistics of these scales, see Appendix 1.

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Appendix 1

Retailer category	Category name	UNNIQLO is similar to retail name	*n*	Minimum	Maximum	Mean	Standard deviation
A	Discount Mens/Womens	Aoyama	868	1	5	3.20	1.085
	Business Suits Specialist Retail Multiples	Aoki	679	1	5	2.36	1.020
B	Upmarket "Smart" Casual Clothing Speciality Stores	United Arrows	795	1	5	3.21	1.065
		Beams	579	1	5	2.99	1.094
C	Global Fashion-Forward Casual Clothing Speciality Store Retail Multiples	H&M	881	1	5	2.14	1.001
		Zara	702	1	5	2.25	1.045
D	Domestic Low-price Casual Clothing Speciality Store Retail Multiples	Right-on	694	1	5	3.02	1.078
		Honeys	789	1	5	3.85	1.041
		Shimamura	369	1	5	2.89	1.084
E	Low-price Fashion-forward Casual Clothing Retail Multiple arm of Fast Retailing	GU	865	1	5	2.16	1.010

Source(s): Authors

Table A1. Descriptive statistics on consumers' perceived similarity score on selected specialist retailers similar to UNIQLO

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Appendix 2

Table A2.
The complete list of the solution terms through an analysis with fsQCA procedures

UNIQLO v.s. Discount Mens / Womens Business Suits Specialist Retail Multiples (AOYAMA and AOKI)								similarity to						
Solution Term	MD	PPR	PER	ACC	GEN	AREA	AGE	AOYAMA	AOKI	Raw Coverage	Unique Coverage	PRI Consittency	Solution Coverage	Solution Consistency
A-1	●	●	●	●	⊠	⊠	●	⊠		0.023	0.015	0.838		
A-2	●	●	●	●	●	⊠	●	●		0.047	0.047	0.782		
A-3	●	●	●	●		●	●	●	●	0.169	0.051	0.771		
A-4	●	●	●		●	⊠	⊠	●	●	0.002	0.002	1.000	0.289	0.850
A-5	⊠	●	●	●	⊠	⊠		●	●	0.029	0.021	0.821		
A-6	●	●	●	●	●	●	●		●	0.082	0.004	0.770		
A-7	●	●	●	●		●	●	⊠	⊠	0.105	0.020	0.792		

UNIQLO v.s. Upmarket 'Smart' Casual Clothing Speciality Stores (United Arrows and Beams)								similarity to						
Solution Term	MD	PPR	PER	ACC	GEN	AREA	AGE	United Arrows	BEAMS	Raw Coverage	Unique Coverage	PRI Consittency	Solution Coverage	Solution Consistency
B-1	●	●	●	●	⊠	●	●			0.124	0.019	0.801		
B-2	●	●	●	●	●		●		⊠	0.086	0.004	0.805		
B-3	●	●	●	●		●	●	●		0.173	0.030	0.774		
B-4	●	●	●	●			●	⊠	⊠	0.163	0.011	0.815		
B-5	⊠	●	●	●	⊠	⊠		●	●	0.027	0.001	0.812	0.320	0.855
B-6	●	●	●	●	●	⊠	●	⊠		0.033	0.007	0.824		
B-7	●	●	●		●	⊠	⊠	●	●	0.003	0.003	1.000		
B-8	⊠	●	●	●	⊠	⊠	⊠	⊠	⊠	0.001	0.001	0.966		
B-9		●	●	●	⊠	⊠	●	●	●	0.056	0.024	0.804		

UNIQLO v.s. Global Fashion-Forward Casual Clothing Speciality Store Retail Multiples (H&M and Zara)								similarity to						
Solution Term	MD	PPR	PER	ACC	GEN	AREA	AGE	H&M	ZARA	Raw Coverage	Unique Coverage	PRI Consittency	Solution Coverage	Solution Consistency
C-1	⊠	●	●	●	⊠	⊠		⊠	⊠	0.022	0.009	0.828		
C-2	⊠	●	●	●	⊠	⊠		●	●	0.017	0.003	0.815		
C-3	●	●	●	●	⊠	●	●	●		0.068	0.016	0.786		
C-4	●	●	●	●	⊠		●	⊠	⊠	0.121	0.048	0.778	0.209	0.852
C-5	●	●	●	●	●	⊠		⊠	●	0.036	0.009	0.774		
C-6	●	●	●	●		⊠	●	●	●	0.067	0.019	0.782		
C-7	●	●	●	⊠	●	⊠	⊠	●	●	0.002	0.001	1.000		

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UNIQLO v.s.								similarity to							
Domestic Low-price Casual Clothing Speciality Store Retail Multiples (Right-on, Honey's, and Shimamura)															
Solution Term	MD	PPR	PER	ACC	GEN	AREA	AGE	Right-on	Honeys	Shima-mura	Raw Coverage	Unique Coverage	PRI Consittency	Solution Coverage	Solution Consistency
D-1	●	●	●	●	☒	●	●				0.124	0.045	0.801		
D-2	☒	●	●	●	☒	☒	☒		●	●	0.002	0.002	0.981		
D-3	☒	●	●	●	☒	☒	●	☒	☒	☒	0.017	0.007	0.787		
D-4	●	●	●	●	●	☒	☒	●	●	●	0.001	0.001	1.000		
D-5	●	●	●	☒	●	☒	☒	☒	●	☒	0.002	0.001	1.000		
D-6	●	●	●	●		●	●	☒		☒	0.144	0.022	0.780	0.291	0.853
D-7	●	●	●	●	●	☒	●	☒		●	0.030	0.003	0.812		
D-8	●	●	●	●	●	☒	●		☒	☒	0.033	0.006	0.750		
D-9	●	●	●	●	●		●	☒	●	●	0.079	0.009	0.792		
D-10	●	●	●	●		☒	●	●	●	☒	0.050	0.004	0.757		
D-11		●	●	●	☒	☒	●	●	●	●	0.037	0.016	0.815		

UNIQLO v.s.								similarity to						
GU (under Fast Retailing) : Low-price Fashion-forward Casual Clothing Retail Multiple														
Solution Term	MD	PPR	PER	ACC	GEN	AREA	AGE	GU			Raw Coverage	Unique Coverage	PRI Consittency	Solution Coverage	Solution Consistency
E-1	●	●	●	●		☒	●				0.114	0.017	0.795		
E-2	●	●	●	●			●	☒			0.291	0.146	0.785		
E-3	☒	●	●	●	☒	☒		☒			0.030	0.018	0.827	0.341	0.845
E-4	●	●	●		●	☒	☒	●			0.002	0.002	1.000		
E-5	●		●	●	☒	●	●	●			0.060	0.013	0.812		

Note(s): ● (Full circle) indicates the presence of a condition
☒ (Crossed-out box) indicates the absence of a condition
MD = Merchandising Excellence, PPR = Attractiveness of Price Promotion,
PER = Store Personnel's Fit with the Store Environment, ACC = Convenient Store Location
GEN = Gender Dummy : 1 = Female, 0 = Male, AREA = Area Dummy: 1 = Reside in Greater Tokyo, 0 = Reside in Kansai
AGE = Age Dummy : 1 = Older (42 years old and above, 0 = Younger (41 years old and below)
Source(s): Authors

Table A2.

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